

I suspect that many 60- and 70-year-old retirees feel the same way.

LIVING A PASSION

I recently met a 41-year-old retiree who keeps so busy he rarely has time to look at his to-do list. He had run a division of a waste-management company, "the world's largest garbage collector." When I met him he had been retired for just over a year.

"So what do you do?" I asked. (Some questions never change.)

He shook his head. "I'm so busy I sometimes feel I should go back to work to relax. When I had a job I prepared ninety-day plans for myself, updating them every month or so. I have to do that now to keep track of my activities."

Why is he so busy? This man's passion is postal history related to diamonds. He's spent twenty years running around the world collecting stamps, envelopes, postmarks, and postcards related to diamonds. He claims to have the world's finest collection of that type, and I believe it. For all I know he could have the world's only collection of that type.

He retired to complete the collection, prepare it for display, get it photographed, and put it on exhibit. In the past year he's been on one continuous collecting trip. He's lived on rice and beans for weeks in small Brazilian diamond-mining towns. He's been to auctions in Frankfurt and Singapore. He's wandered through junk shops in Tahiti, Ecuador, and South Africa.

He also finds time to play the clarinet, collect South American paintings, and write short pieces about his travels. "When I first retired," he says, "I had vague ideas of what I wanted to do. The ideas didn't crystallize until I got going on them. After a while I realized I couldn't do nearly all the things I had hoped to. Now I keep huge file folders with things I want to do, just like when I worked. Maybe someday I'll get to them all."